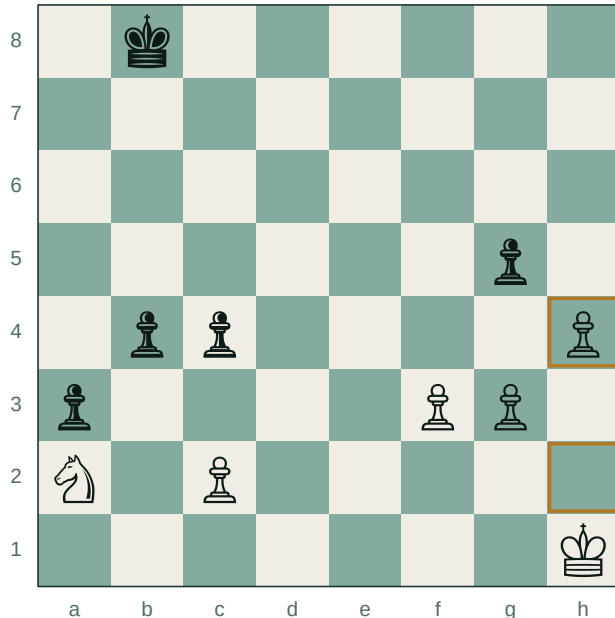


Knight-ending routes: Black, move 38

Knight-ending routes

Black to move



Previous move: 38.h4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

38...b3 39. cxb3 cxb3

38...b3 The pawn moves from b4 to b3. Recorded reply: **39.cxb3**.

39...cxb3 The pawn captures the pawn on b3.

At the end, nominal material is White 6 / Black 3 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +0: the balance goes from -3 to -3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A knight changes color with every move and may need a detour. Check the route square by square before trusting a race estimate.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Knight endings reward exact route calculation. Forks can change a pawn race, while a distant passer may outrun the knight's short-range movement.

HOW TO LOOK

Map the knight's checking moves and its route to the critical blockade square. Count moves rather than judging distance by appearance.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: knight on a2. Check for tactical protection.